Our Solar System

A Star at the Centre

The Sun is a star. It is a giant, glowing ball of hot gas, and it is the closest star to Earth. The Sun sits at the centre of our solar system. It gives us light and heat, and without it, life on Earth could not survive. The Sun is so big that more than one million Earths could fit inside it.

The Eight Planets in Order

Eight planets travel around the Sun. In order from the Sun, they are Mercury, Venus, Earth, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus and Neptune. A fun way to remember the order is the sentence: My Very Excellent Mother Just Served Us Noodles. Mercury is the closest planet to the Sun, and Neptune is the farthest.

Rocky Planets and Giant Planets

The four inner planets, Mercury, Venus, Earth and Mars, are small rocky planets. They have hard, solid surfaces made of rock and metal. The four outer planets are giants. Jupiter and Saturn are gas giants, made mostly of hydrogen and helium gas. Uranus and Neptune are ice giants, made of icy materials like water, ammonia and methane. Jupiter is the largest planet of all.

Gravity Keeps Planets in Orbit

Why don't the planets fly off into space? The answer is gravity. Gravity is a pulling force. The Sun is so massive that its gravity pulls on every planet. Each planet is moving very fast, and the Sun's gravity bends its path into a curved loop called an orbit. Planets closer to the Sun take less time to go around it. Earth takes one year to orbit the Sun once.

Moons and More

Many planets have moons that orbit them, held by the planet's own gravity. Earth has one Moon, but Saturn and Jupiter each have dozens. Our solar system also has dwarf planets like Pluto, rocky asteroids, and icy comets.